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Entry level cell phones

and rudimentary music play-back. Some phones even had a full QWERTY keypad while others could play videos. All these features on an entry-level phone were unthinkable just a couple of years back. Being the personal devices that they are, we feel such additions are necessary, after all, who doesn't like a converged device? And why should one pay the earth for one?

No frills (no thrills?) (Up to Rs 2,500)

We had the most basic phones in this category. We laid more stress on calling functionality and messaging rather than on features like camera and audio in this segment.

Features

A lot of interesting phones were identified in this category and it also threw in a lot of firsts for us. For instance we got this full QWERTY Olive V-G8000 which were surprised to find in this category. It is a single SIM phone without a camera with a wide 2.2-inch screen. The keypad has isolated buttons which seem a bit tiny and will get used to

for someone moving from a regular keypad to a QWERTY one.

The other phone from Olive, the V-G2300 had another surprise element which we felt will be seen in many entry-level phones in the future. It has support for AAA batteries, as an alternate source of power. It has a well designed rubberised keypad and supports FM and has a speaker phone functionality.

ZTE G-S202 was a phone which anyone can mistake for a calculator thanks to its large number pad. This is one of the few phones which have a larger space dedicated to the keypad than the screen. It was the only monochrome phone that we

got and supports only calling, messaging and FM. The backlit display is wonderful and an LED torch is located on top.

Nokia's 1209 and 1662 were also present in this category. Of the two we felt that 1662 has a poorly designed keypad with stiff buttons. 1209 on the other hand had a smaller screen but a comparatively better designed keypad. Intex IN2020E was

the only camera phone in this segment. As far as build quality goes IN2020E and g-Fone 345 left a lot to be desired.

Videocon V1305, g-Fone 351N, g-Fone 345 and Intex IN2020E also support dual SIM functionality which was another interesting aspect.

Performance

We concentrated on the call strength and call quality more than any other feature. All the phones performed well in the Zone 1 test, but that wasn't the case in Zone 2. The call on g-Fone 345 was dropped after a couple of seconds whereas Olive V-G2300 and ZTE GS202 gave a poor quality call quality in Zone 2. The speaker quality on 345 and 351N was quite good as compared to the other phones. Camera quality of the Intex IN2020E was poor.

A step up: basics plus some more (Rs. 2,501 to Rs. 4,200)

This category comprised dual SIM cellphones. It had phones that had slightly more features than phones in the previous

category. Obviously, at this price range people are going to expect better multimedia capabilities.

Features

In this category we identified nine phones. Intex IN 4477 and Olive V-G200 were two phones that stood out in this segment whereas we were surprised to find a full QWERTY keypad enabled fly B430. IN4477 is the best in terms of looks thanks to its strong all metal body. The rear flap has a brush metal finish whereas the keypad has a glossy metallic finish. Olive VG200 on the other hand has a wide 2.2-inch screen which also has touchscreen functionality. Fly B430 has a nicely designed keypad, but its rear flap tends to bend in certain parts. It also has a 1.3MP camera.

Videocon's dual sim phones in this category V1306, V1402 and V1405 have a variety as far as the design element is concerned. While V1306 is very ordinary to look at, V1402 and V1405 have interesting keypad design. The navigation pad on V1405 is poorly designed though. The rear flaps on all



Intex IN 2020E



g-Fone 345

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